

at 160 kmph. Later christened Vande Bharat, the trains were tested at speeds of above 180 kmph. Such speeds were unheard of in a country where the average speed of a superfast train is 55-60 kmph while for premium trains, it is 65-70 kmph.

“We wanted to build the country’s first indigenous semi-high-speed train. As I was retiring in December 2018, I told the team that we had 18 months to complete the task from concept to delivery or the project may get dropped... The team delivered,” says Mani, who retired after the first Vande Bharat train was produced. The 16-coach self-propelled locomotive-less train, equipped with modern amenities and enhanced safety features, was built at a cost of ₹98 crore. If India had imported a set of 10 such train with technology transfer, the cost would have been around ₹225-250 crore per train. Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off the first Vande Bharat train between Delhi and Varanasi in February 2019.

Cut to 2024, and there are 51 Vande Bharat trains (102 services) running across the country. The plan is to have 800 Vande Bharat trains—including new variants—by 2030 (*see chart ‘Picking up the Pace’*). The government has awarded tenders to manufacture 412 train sets at a total cost of more than ₹90,000 crore; these trains are to be operationalised in the next three years. India is also eyeing the export market after 2030.

The growing demand for Vande Bharat trains has spurred some players in the space to get into partnerships and expand capacity. From PSUs such as BEML, Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd (BHEL) and Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd (RVNL) to private players like Titagarh



PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH

**UNION RAILWAY
MINISTER ASHWINI
VAISHNAW
RECENTLY SAID
THAT THE TRIALS
FOR THE SLEEPER
VERSION OF VANDE
BHARAT WERE
EXPECTED TO BE
COMPLETED IN
AUGUST**

TIMELINE

**Aug
2021**



**PM ANNOUNCES 75 SERVICES
DURING ‘AMRIT MAHOTSAV’**

**Dec
2022**



**FOUR VANDE BHARAT TRAINS
LAUNCHED AFTER 2019**

**July
2024**



**51 VANDE BHARAT TRAINS (102
SERVICES) OPERATIONAL**